at the hotel, watching daytime television. For those couple of hours, I was really down. If I couldn't even get to watch training, never mind be part of it, what chance did I have? Now, here I was, within touching distance. But I still wasn't sure. Was I days away from all the hard work with the trainers paying off? Or days away from a disappointment that I just couldn't imagine myself having to face?

The opening game against Sweden in Saitama was still a week away. Sven didn't push me. He wanted to give me as long as possible. But he couldn't afford for that to interfere with preparing the rest of the team. With a longer-term injury, the doctors will always set you weekly targets. That's partly so they can make sure you push yourself on to the next stage, whether that's running on hard ground or twisting and turning or hitting a ball with full force. But it's also to make sure a player doesn't get depressed by focusing too far ahead. Psychologically, the secret is to concentrate on what you're doing from day to day. Now, though, I'd reached the point of no return. Would I be able to take part in a competitive game by the end of the week? Sven knew—and I knew—that the time had come when a decision had to be made. If I couldn't join in full training in the days before the game then, obviously, playing was out of the question. I know the medical team were confident about my foot but not so sure about my overall fitness: I'd been out a long time. The decision was the manager's to make. Wednesday arrived, the very last day he could afford for me not to be working with everybody else. I'd known all along that Sven would want to take a chance on me as long as the odds were in mine, and England's, favor. He knew that I hadn't come this far to duck out at the end of it. Even if I didn't feel one hundred percent, I was sure I could make it. After breakfast, Sven asked me the question:

'Well, are you fit?'

He knew the answer and I didn't pick up any trace of doubt or tension in his voice. He wanted to hear it from me and to know I was confident. I gulped a little air and tried to keep it as short and nerveless as Sven had done.

'I'm fit.'

'Good. Let's go.'

The first session with the rest of the boys was difficult. I'd been working really hard, running and kicking a ball. This was the first time I'd had to risk physical contact. I should have seen it coming: as soon as we were into a game, the first crunching challenge came in from Martin Keown—who else? He didn't actually make contact with the injury: it was a clump across the